Jefferson Dual Assignment: Community Engagement Summary

Invitations were sent to all families who reside in the Jefferson Dual Assignment zone who are attending a Portland Public School. During the month of September, PPS staff shared information about the progress of the modernization as well as the upcoming meetings regarding proposed changes to dual assignment at tables during back to school nights at thirteen sites**.** The K5 schools included: Beach, Chief Joseph, Boise-Eliot/Humboldt, Sabin, Irvington, Peninsula, Dr. Martin Luther King Jr., and Woodlawn. Staff also attended Vernon K8 and Faubion PK8 nights as well as at Harriet Tubman Middle and Ockley Green Middle Schools, and at Jefferson High School. The purpose was to raise awareness of the changes that were happening at Jefferson which included both the modernization of the building site as well as changes to student assignment, and to preview upcoming engagement opportunities.

During the month of October and November the Office of School Planning and Modernization worked in collaboration with the Family and Community Engagement team along with the Strategic Project Management Office, and the Office of School Performance to host six community listening sessions**.** The purpose of the engagements was twofold, to share information about how dual assignment would be sunsetted, the scenarios, and how they performed on the required criteria outlined in board policy that should be considered. Secondly, the events were designed to provide families a chance to give feedback and ask questions.

We posted the materials on the Jefferson is Rising website on Friday October 17, three days before the first engagement session so that families could review them prior to coming to one of the sessions. We met with two groups of community members to get input on the process for the sessions. Facilitators and notetakers were assigned to each group. Notes were compiled from each group and shared with our Research, Accountability and Assessment Team.

Timeline of events

Our community engagement sessions began with informally sharing information at thirteen Back to School Nights in September, followed by a series of six community events in October and November. The details are attached.

Summary of findings

During the sessions, community members provided feedback through polls, small group discussions and an online feedback survey. The survey was also posted online and remained active through November 14. There were a total of 244 responses to the feedback survey, 37% of the respondents attended the session at Harriet Tubman Middle school followed by 24% of whom did not attend any session. (The details can be found in Table 1 in the Summary of Findings).

81% of participants agreed that the materials presented during the engagement sessions were presented in a way that was easy to understand. A majority of the respondents reported that

they felt neutral to good about their overall experience, however nearly a third of participants felt that they were not heard during the sessions. In the future, we need to either hold longer sessions so that more time can be dedicated to discussion or we will break the sessions into two meetings each with defined purposes - informational or feedback. In addition, in future engagements we will ask participants to voluntarily report demographic data such as schools where their students attend, community role, participant race/ethnicity, and programs that their students participate in such as dual language immersion. This will support our efforts to ensure representativeness of the respondents.

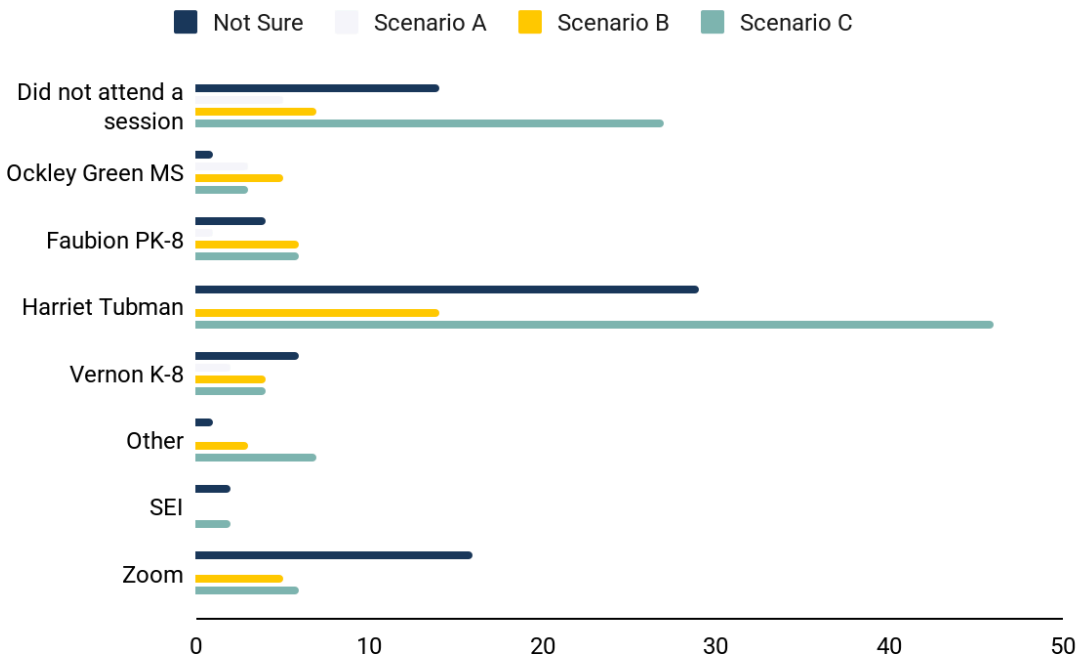
We asked families if they had any questions about the process or Jefferson is Rising. These questions fell into three broad categories:

- **Questions about academic and extracurricular programming at Jefferson High School**, including how PPS will provide comparable access to Advanced Placement courses, electives, and sports before JHS reaches full enrollment
- **Questions about the timeline of this process**, including why the transition must take place before construction is complete in 2029
- **Questions about students' experiences attending a school while construction is ongoing**, including safety and noise concerns

We also asked families which scenario they felt best supported a strong neighborhood school. Overall 44% of the respondents preferred Scenario C which has Peninsula K5 and Beach Spanish Immersion feeding to Roosevelt, Irvington feeding to Grant and Faubion, Vernon, Woodlawn, Chief Joseph, Beach neighborhood students, Dr. Martin Luther King Jr students (both neighborhood and DLI), Boise-Eliot/Humboldt, and Sabin feeding to Jeffrson. 32% of respondents were not sure or needed more information. There was some variation in responses depending on which engagement session they attended (Chart 1). For example during the virtual meeting, the majority of respondents were undecided.

During the engagement sessions participants were asked to rank their priorities when considering the future of Jefferson. Participants were in agreement that offering a wide range of academic programs, college and career pathways, and extracurricular opportunities and course progressions were very important or important (145 of 151 responses). Families also expressed the importance of students being geographically close to their home and community (127 of 152) as well as the importance of long-term sustainability and future growth for Jefferson students (114 out of 142).

Chart 1: Count of preferred scenario by listening session attendance



Listening Session

401 community members participated in the six listening sessions. Some families were able to attend multiple sessions and we added a session at the Tony Hopson Center for Self Enhancement to increase the participation of our families of color.

When analyzing the table notes, information from the virtual session and the session at SEI were not available at the time of review. Families at SEI shared that they wanted tangible evidence of PPS' commitment to the Jefferson community. Four themes emerged across the sessions:

Theme 1: Disrupted trust between the district and constituents

Many shared that they felt the decision had already been made, and wished they had been engaged earlier.

Theme 2: Desire for clarity before commitment

Participants expressed significant concern regarding course and extracurricular offerings at Jefferson High School in the period leading up to full enrollment. Families reported wanting to see a written plan for academic and extracurricular access before sunsetting Dual Assignment.

Theme 3: Opposition to the proposed timeline

Community members repeatedly expressed concern about the timeline, namely:

(1) sending students to a school under active construction and

(2) insufficient time to authentically engage the community while making

informed choices.

Many expressed that they would be excited to send their students to Jefferson High School after the building modernization project has been completed.

Theme 4: Gentrification and changing racial dynamics at Jefferson High School

Many participants expressed concern regarding how increasing enrollment at Jefferson High School will significantly shift the school culture. Relatedly, participants raised a concern that the needs of the Latine community were not being taken into consideration, especially at Roosevelt High School. They expressed concern that this enrollment shift would have a destabilizing effect on this and other communities of color across Portland Public Schools.

As a result of the community feedback regarding the need for another measure of proximity, we created additional maps to highlight the density of student populations that are within 1.0 and 1.5 miles of each of the four high schools. In addition, we worked with staff from Secondary Academics and Jefferson administrators to outline a timeline, process and framework for expanding the academic offerings at Jefferson to provide both breadth and depth of courses that build on the strengths of current programming as it transitions from a focus option to a comprehensive high school.